

THE ESSAY

An Essay is the result of a process that should consist in the following passages.

1. Normally an essay starts from a question. First of all, you have to interpret the question: **understand what you are asked to do**. The question may not ask you to give examples, but you should always provide some.
2. You should now work out your basic ideas. Brainstorm your ideas and jot them down: you can use a diagram, a list, a table, etc...
3. Organize your notes: underline them in different ways according to the paragraph you decide to fit them in.
4. Select the key ideas to develop in the essay and the information to complete them (supporting ideas, examples).
5. Start writing your essay, dividing it clearly into paragraphs (introduction, 2-3 discussion paragraphs, conclusion).
6. Edit your text: monitor grammar spelling, coherence and cohesion.

There are three key elements of an essay.

1. **Introduction**
2. **Body Paragraphs**
3. **Conclusion**

1) Introduction

You should do just two things:

- State the topic of the essay, using some basic facts (that you may be able to take from the question)
- Say what you are going to write about

2) Body Paragraphs

You should have 2 or 3 body paragraphs - no more, and no less.

For your body paragraph, each paragraph should contain one **controlling idea**, and have sentences to **support** this.

Be careful to gather the ideas on the same point of the topic into the same paragraph, so that the essay moves forward instead of jumping around. Moreover, take care of the logical relationship between paragraphs.

One way of doing this is to structure your paragraphs as follows:

- First sentence or **topic sentence**: it contains the **main statement**.
- **Subsequent sentences** that justify and illustrate the main statement.
- **Final sentence**: to sum up the paragraph.

Write your essay in clear paragraphs, using phrases such as “first of all”, “in addition” or “To sum up” to start each paragraph.

3) Conclusion

The conclusion only needs to be one or two sentences, and you can do the following:

- Re-state what the essay is about (re-write the last sentence of your introduction in different words)
- Give some thoughts about the future

Remember that your essay should have a style which is different from the way you talk. So try to develop a register which avoids characteristics of speech such as contracted forms; try not to use too complex sentences; do not refer to yourself as “one” or “we”, and use “I” only when you introduce a personal note.

Editing

Editing means checking grammar spelling and cohesion. Look out for:

- Grammar mistakes;
- Proper use of lexis and syntax;
- Lexical repetitions;
- Spelling mistakes.